

YAHWEH. TRICKSTER.

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Few, if any, studies consider Yahweh as a trickster figure.¹ This paper begins to fill that gap. Next to renowned tricksters like the West African Eshu and the Native American Coyote, the Hebrew god pales in comparison. He is far more serious, and thus his omission among the company of tricksters is understandable. Notwithstanding, I show how traces of a Hebrew trickster god lurk between the lines of Rabbinical redactions. To begin, I formulate a basis for identifying the trickster archetype. Then, I examine Old Testament stories from Genesis to Job to demonstrate how Yahweh's portrayal does in fact suggest a trickster motif, and when considered as a corpus suggest a pattern that is linked to subtle changes in God's embodied form.

Several scholars have examined Biblical tricksters and trickster figures in Hebraic folklore. Among them, Susan Niditch in *Underdogs and Tricksters: A Prelude to Biblical Folklore* analyzes the stories of Jacob, Esther and others, using Stith and Thompson's typology and Propp's morphological tools to cull out thematic components of Hebraic trickster tales. Still others, such as J. J. M. Roberts, focus on Yahweh's deceit and the general role of deceit in the Bible ("Does God Lie?"). But, as I came to discover in my research, few if any specifically discuss Yahweh as a trickster figure. Admittedly, next to renowned tricksters like the West African Eshu and the Native American Coyote, Yahweh pales in comparison. He is far more serious, far less burlesque, and consequently far less fun. Notwithstanding, I detect traces of a Hebrew trickster god lurking between the lines of Rabbinical redactions.

Dean Andrew Nicholas in *The Trickster Revisited: Deception as a Motif in the Pentateuch* suggests that during the development of the Biblical texts preexisting trickster elements may have lost their meaning, or were felt to be irrelevant or undesired and therefore may have been edited out. He also argues for an interpretive skewing by biblical editors: "By reading allegorically or inventing mitigating circumstances,

¹ In this paper I use the names Yahweh and God interchangeably to reference the monotheistic deity of the Hebrew Bible.

traditional exegetes pushed the deception theme into the background” (1). Nicholas demonstrates how this continues to happen: “Even modern commentators attempt to deduce patriarchal motives to depict Abram in a more positive manner” (2). Scholar Benjamin D. Sommers in *The Bodies of God and the World of Ancient Israel* also brings to light a collective blind spot. He addresses Yahweh’s obvious embodiment in the Hebrew Bible: “The God of the Hebrew Bible has a body. This must be stated at the outset, because so many people, including many scholars, assume otherwise. The evidence for this simple thesis is overwhelming” (1). Could this cultural oversight extend to include the trickster qualities of Yahweh? Could a fresh reading of the text discern an embodied, engaged and mischievous god? Could the evident lies, punishments and clever bargaining of this tricky god have at one time been understood just as necessary to the perpetuation of community as the sun is to the turning of the seasons? These are the questions I seek answers to below.

To begin, I review the general cross-cultural traits of the trickster, then highlight the characteristics some have observed with regard to Hebrew tricksters to formulate a basis for evaluating whether Yahweh fits amongst those that populate the general field. I have selected several stories involving Adam and Eve, Abraham and Sarah, Moses, the Philistines and Job to examine how the portrayal of God suggests a trickster motif. Finally, I argue when the stories are considered as a corpus they lend themselves to such a portrayal and further suggest a pattern that is linked to changes in God’s physical form.

THE TRICKSTER REVISITED

The term trickster only came into vogue in the latter half of the nineteenth century, coined by Daniel Brinton in *The Myths of the New World* (*Trickster Revisited* 9). Since then scholars have examined the trickster figure from a multitude of approaches (e.g., psychology, folklore, religion, literature, mythology) within a wide range of cultures. Several useful studies summarize the common characteristics found in trickster figures cross-culturally. One succinct list is provided by William J. Hynes author of “Mapping the Characteristics of Mythic Tricksters: A Heuristic Guide” (34). Barbara Babcock-Abrahams offers a more detailed list (159-160). I have amalgamated the two lists below and have added a few other well-known features mentioned by other scholars:

1. anomalous, liminal, a loner, creator and destroyer
2. deceiver, trick-player, situation inverter
3. gender ambiguity, shapeshifter, capable of disguise, singular or multiple
4. messenger, imitator of the gods; or the reverse, i.e., he recruits agents for his tasks
5. sexual and appetite excesses, scatological focus
6. culture-hero, or advocate of culture-hero
7. amoral, aggressive, vindictive or vain
8. ability to make us laugh at the his/her (trickster’s) foolishness

With these general guidelines in mind, I highlight below biblical stories which suggest Yahweh's trickster proclivities.

ADAM AND EVE: GOD AS LONER, CREATOR, TRICKSTER AND CULTURE-HERO

I pick up where the Bible starts—"in the beginning," before creation. God appears, alone. We are not told where he comes from, or of his history or genealogy (Gen. 1:1). He is just there. Some, like Jack Miles, conjecture that perhaps in his solitary existence he becomes lonely (36), or rather that he seeks to know himself through a reflection of his image (28). Whatever his motivation, Yahweh creates a world, much like any seven-year-old would in my psychotherapy office when guided to a tray of sand and figurines with the invitation, "If you wish, make a world in the sand." By his actions, God identifies himself as a creator—a characteristic of trickster gods.

Yahweh also operates from a liminal place—neither fully of this world nor of the next, at least at the beginning of the story when he has a more embodied presence. Tricksters must be liminal figures in order to provoke change. Victor Turner phrased it this way: "Liminality may perhaps be regarded as the Nay to all positive structural assertions, but as in some sense the source of them all, and more than that, as a realm of pure possibility whence novel configurations of ideas and relations may arise" (97). Perhaps Yahweh becomes dissatisfied, lonely, or restless so he inverts the situation and brings about a reversal of what had been the status quo—chaos to order, non-being to being, unmanifest to manifest. In short, he brings change.

Other trickster traits stand out here as well, such as his loner status which continues throughout the Bible. His solitary existence is especially pronounced when placed in juxtaposition to pagan gods named in the Bible who belong to a greater community of gods and goddesses. How did Yahweh become such a renegade, a god operating without community? Is he an outcast god, or perhaps in exile? God's loner status and gender, though, is ambiguous in Genesis: "And God said, 'Let us make man in our image, after our likeness.' . . . And God created man in His image, in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them" (Gen. 1:26-27). Who does the "us" refer to? The royal we—me, myself and I—indicative of the loner? Or, does "us" refer to an unmentioned partner, or to his multiplicity in unity and thus a lack of gender differentiation? Any one of these possible interpretations points to trickster features.

Adam and Eve hear "the sound of the Lord God moving about in the garden at the breezy time of day. . . . The Lord God called out to the man and said to him, 'Where are you?'" (Gen. 3:8-9). Adam and Eve are hiding, having just discovered their nakedness. There seems little doubt that the episode involving Eve and the serpent in the Garden of Eden story involves trickery. Ziony Zevit In *What Really Happened in the Garden of Eden* explains the subtle and leading language used by the serpent to entice

Eve to eat from the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Bad (167). However, does the trickery originate with the serpent, or is the serpent merely the agent of its creator, God? Whatever the case, in a Promethean-like grab, Eve steals wisdom for humanity. Based on his careful translation, Zevit argues that God does not ban the couple from Eden. Instead he foresees an over-population crisis, so he sends Adam, Eve, and their growing family out of the Garden to join the rest of humanity (241). No longer naked (i.e., innocent), Adam and Eve now have the wisdom needed to discern good from bad. Such knowledge will no doubt help them spot trickery, but such knowledge will also aid them to commit deception as well.

To summarize, in this small but important section of the Bible, Yahweh reveals his trickster leanings. He is a liminal figure, a loner, possesses an ambiguous gender identity, is devious, and acts with an impetus towards cultural development and progress through an emissary and culture hero, in this story, Eve.

ABRAHAM AND SARAH: GOD AS LIAR, DECEIVER AND FOOL

Of Abraham, Niditch writes:

Deceiver, creator, acculturator, unmasked liar, survivor—these qualities of the trickster do apply to the deceiving, ethically ambiguous survivor Abram of Genesis 12:10-20. It is appropriate that this progenitor of the Israelites, traditional founder of Yahwism, first participant in the special covenant of one group with God, be portrayed as a trickster. He is a creator and culture maker of sorts . . . Admittedly, con man might be a more accurate designation. (45)

That being said, was Yahweh tarred with the same brush as this patriarch? The evidence suggests so. Abraham's first interaction with God involves something of a bargain. Yahweh promises Abraham prosperity, fame and power if Abraham agrees to move to Canaan: "I will make of you a great nation / And I will bless you / I will make your name great" (Gen. 12: 2). On at least four subsequent occasions God repeats the promise while adding that Abraham will father many children. At one point, completely disbelieving God's words, Abraham laughs in his face (Gen. 17:17). As Miles notes: "The effect of the Lord's four-times-repeated promise of fertility is to inspire not trust but doubt in the reader . . . A promise that was superfluous in the first place is repeated, repeated, repeated again to what becomes, as it is not kept, an effect of mounting unease" (50). God reneges on his first deal. And, thereafter, his unfulfilled promises ring like hollow boasts of power. Since no children are forthcoming, Sarah and Abraham devise a plan for Abraham to lie with Sarah's handmaid, Hagar. As Nicholas writes: "Abram did not trust God and depended on his own deceptive plan rather than God" (2).

Yahweh's deceptiveness is also apparent when he instructs Abraham to take Isaac to Moriah and sacrifice him as a burnt offering (Gen. 22: 1-2). As we know, Yahweh stays

Abraham's hand and Isaac does not die. Could it be that Abraham harbors doubt around whether Yahweh will really go through with the sacrifice of Isaac, and decides to feign acceptance and go along with the Hebrew god's game of chicken? The relationship between Abraham and his god seems rife with tension. Abraham seeks to appease a god who offers him wealth and power for his submission. And, God strings Abraham along to see how much obedience he can wring out of him. One has a sense of a relationship built on mind trips, power games and manipulations.

THE PHILISTINES: THE SCATALOGICAL AND VORACIOUS GOD

One of the more amusing aspects of the trickster god in other mythologies is his voracious appetite and his preoccupation with sex and excrement. Yahweh does not seem to share these off-color aspects. An exception, however, might be found in First Samuel when God strikes out at the Philistines: "the hand of the Lord lay heavy upon the Ashdodites, and He wrought havoc among them: He struck Ashdod and its territory with hemorrhoids" (1 Sam. 5:6). He repeats this anal treatment with the people of Gath and Ekron. The priests recommend that the plighted people appease the god of Israel by fashioning five golden hemorrhoids and five golden mice as an offering (1 Sam. 6:4-5). The *Hebrew Study Bible* with regard to hemorrhoids notes that: "some scholars, however identify the disease as bubonic plague, since instead of hemorrhoids, the Heb 'ketiv' ('what is written') reads 'tumors,' which are characteristic of bubonic plague" (570). Is this a valid correction or an attempt to write out a humorous and scatological aspect of the Hebrew god? It is hard to keep a straight face when picturing the enemy beleaguered by such a malady. As a battle tactic, it seems a creative and effective method for hampering the opposition while adding insult to injury through humiliation—pure trickster.

The trickster is often a comical character who lives by his wits, breaking social boundaries and using deception and trickery to survive. While usually cunning, he is also made to look the fool, overcome by his voracious appetite—both gastronomical and sexual. Because trickster is typically a base character, the tales tend to be full of scatological and sexual humor. (*The Trickster Revisited* 9)

A hint of Yahweh's "voracious appetite" might be found in the many blood sacrifices that are continually offered to him—(e.g., burnt, sin, guilt, peace)—and exemplified in this episode with the golden hemorrhoids (1 Sam. 6:15). His appetite also completely spirals out of control when he directs Abraham to sacrifice Isaac. While his hunger is not literally gastronomical (although with all the bloody offerings it could be argued otherwise), he seems endlessly craving recognition, attention and obedience.

MOSES: GOD AS GAME CHANGER, TRICK-PLAYER AND INVERTER

The story of the Jews' escape from Egypt led by Moses highlights further trickster aspects of the Hebrew god. Moses first meets God on Horeb where Moses encounters the burning bush from which the voice of God emanates (Exod. 3:1-6). God seems to express empathy and compassion for his people now enslaved by the Egyptians. Again we see God making bargains. He offers to ride shotgun if Moses will go to the Pharaoh to ask for freedom. Once released from their bondage, the deal on the table is that the people will come to the mountain to worship God: "I will be with you . . . And when you have freed the people from Egypt, you shall worship God at this mountain (Exod. 3:12). And, so it goes that Moses follows Yahweh's instructions. He takes his brother Aaron with him and together they demand of the Pharaoh the release of the Israelites based on their greater power demonstrated by a feat of magic made possible by God's invisible hand. Yahweh makes sure that the magic of Moses surpasses the Egyptian priests whereby proving their superiority and right for freedom. God is pulling other strings and hardens the heart of the Pharaoh so that the Pharaoh stubbornly refuses (Exod. 7:3, 7:8). God does not want the Pharaoh to acquiesce right away; he wants the opportunity to display his power, and perhaps by that display of power elicit from the Egyptian people fear and respect. His plan unfolds. This repeated pattern of request, display of power, and refusal continues until Yahweh allows the Pharaoh to relent and to release the Israelites. The trickster God manipulates the situation one more time, luring the Egyptians into a trap whereby they are drowned as he sends the waters of the Red Sea crashing over them during their pursuit of the Israelites (Exod. 14:26-31).

The episodes involving Moses display Yahweh as a trick player, and demonstrate his ability to reverse the status of his people. While in other stories, such as those referred to earlier, the Hebrew god might be an advocate for a culture-hero that moves society forward, however here it seems that he assumes the role of culture-hero himself.

JOB: GOD AS SHAPESHIFTER AND AMORAL AGGRESSOR

In the Hebrew Bible, God on occasion displays his ability to appear physically. In these instances, his appearance varies. Previous to the Book of Job, God's shape has human features. For example, he walks through the Garden of Eden. Other times though, God takes on forms of nature such as a burning bush (Exod. 3:2), a pillar of cloud (Exod. 14:19), or a volcano-like entity of cloud and fire (Exod. 40:33-38, *God a Biography* 126). In the Book of Job, God shape-shifts into a tempest (Job 38:1), and speaks his last words in the Hebrew Bible. God has sent the Adversary to cause Job grief by harming his property and loved ones. The story of Job tells of God's intent to settle a bet with the Adversary as to whether under extreme duress Job will buckle and become impious. God instructs the Adversary to do as he wishes as long as Job is not physically harmed. I question whether God is motivated out of kindness or cruelty given the severity of the disasters that befall Job. God's tendency towards vindictiveness, aggression and amorality is well documented in the books preceding Job. But, it is in the poignant

and thought-provoking text of Job where his unethical character is more fully exposed and God's scruples can be seriously questioned. Job himself challenges God's very character. As Miles writes: "God's last words are those he speaks to Job, the human being who dares to challenge not his physical power but his moral authority." Miles continues:

Within the Book of Job itself, God's climatic and overwhelming reply seems to silence Job. But reading from the end of the Book of Job onward, we see that it is Job who has somehow silenced God. God never speaks again. . . . What is the meaning of the long twilight of the Hebrew Bible, its ten closing books of silence? . . . God does not die. But he never again intervenes in human affairs, and by accumulating implication, no further intervention is expected of him. (11)

GOD: THE TRAGIC TRICKSTER

The foregoing discussion of the Biblical god suggests a valid comparison to the trickster archetype. Arguing against such an identification of Yahweh as trickster, however, is the nearly complete absence of humor associated with the Hebrew deity. Most other tricksters have an inherent lightness mixed into their dual nature as creators and destroyers. That lightness is difficult to find in the Hebrew Bible. Scholar Susan Niditch while speaking of biblical trickster figures such as Jacob and David remarks that Hebrew tricksters are far more understated:

Although Biblical tricksters are a much more sedate version of the character type than the bawdy examples of West African mythology, they display some of the same ambiguities in motivation and realization of goals. They never gain full control of the situation around them and often escape difficulties in a less than noble way. Their tale does not end with unequivocal success, but they survive to trick again. (xi)

She also notes a special emphasis on the underdog aspect of the trickster with regard to Hebraic mythology (xi). I wonder, though, if further study might uncover God's mirthfulness in Midrashic interpretations. The wholesale absence of the comic culture-hero suggests, at least to me, an editorial hand with an agenda. For, the complete lack of humor seems counter to human nature. It does not accurately reflect how human beings respond to adversity—often with the balm of laughter. I am reminded of my grandfather's funeral and the horrible case of funeral giggles my sisters and I had as one of his favorite country western songs played, "Don't Fence Me In." He would have been delighted at the ring of laughter filling that somber hall. In hindsight that experience encapsulates the trickster's duality and one of the trickster's functions in the unfolding of humanity's story—a way of carrying mirth and humility through the inevitable tribulations that life presents to us all.

What is the price we pay in our Judeo-Christian dominated society with a sanitized deity unable to hold the dualism of light and dark? As others, like C. G. Jung have noted a need arises for an object to project upon. So, we call upon the Devil, a group, or an individual to label as evil. Babcock-Abrahams puts it this way:

“Marginality” may also be distinguished into its comic and tragic modalities in both life and art. Given the tragic emphasis of the Judeo-Christian tradition, the focus generally falls on the tragic type and pattern. In this modality, the individual who violates the boundaries of what is generally conceived as the social or human structure is punished and the social order is preserved by the projection of evil onto the victim. (“A Tolerated Margin of Mess” 184)

All this is not to say that the Hebrew tragic trickster has failed in its function. Babcock-Abrahams outlines the range of cultural functions that tricksters might serve in their communities which I summarize here—entertainment, social charter, rebellion, social criticism instigating change, cognitive dissonance in the service of creative self-reflection, and the creation of *communitas* (182-184). The predominant functional themes of the stories presented in this paper are social charter and *communitas*. In each story—with the exception of Job—when God intervenes he furthers the stability of the community (social charter) and strengthens the community spirit (*communitas*). Niditch explains how the history of the Israelite peoples undoubtedly influenced the tenor and purpose of their stories:

Claiming rights to a land miles from its roots . . . its major historical leitmotifs themes of enslavement and escape, exile and restoration . . . Israel produced narratives that ultimately served to shore up group identity and self-esteem, that emphasized independence from and superiority over hostile enemies, and that proclaimed Israelite uniqueness. The stories of Israelite heroes not only reflect the community that is Israel, but, indeed, helped to form it. (xii)

The martial nature of the Hebrew god, which Miles emphasizes in his interpretation, certainly would seem necessary given the adversity of the Israelites' existence. But, such a warrior-based god might also ultimately eliminate any inherently comic aspect, a quality which can be perceived as weakness.

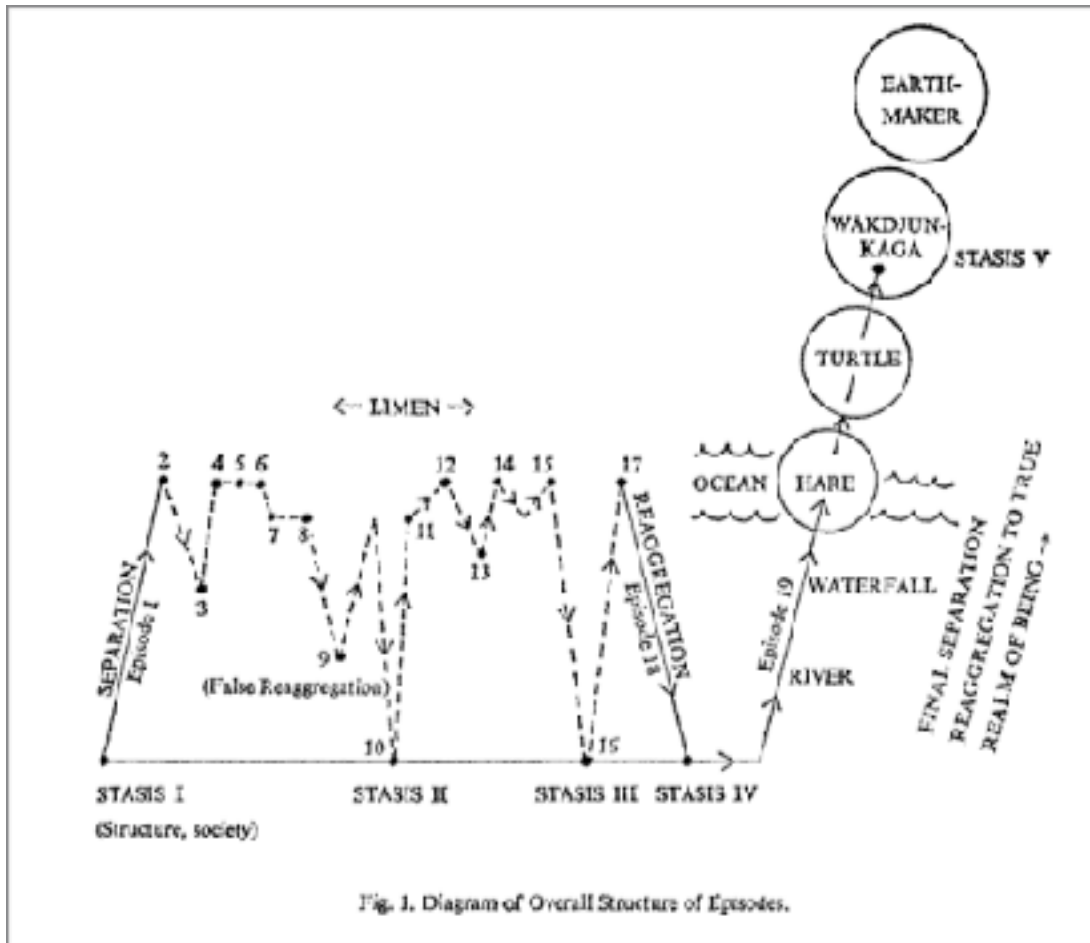


Fig. 1. Pattern of the Winnegago trickster myth from Barbara Babcock-Abrahams' "A Tolerated Margin of Mess," 172.

I suspect, though, that Yahweh's role as trickster continues. Babcock-Abrahams' charts the pattern of the Winnegago trickster myth (fig. 1), a pattern that resonates with Yahweh's journey through the Hebrew Bible, especially his gradual dis-embodiment and removal from the human sphere. Babcock-Abrahams explains:

In this episode Wakdjunkaga [trickster] remembers what he was created to do, performs a series of beneficent deeds for mankind, crosses the ocean, and ascends to the world below Earthmaker of which he is in charge. His extended sojourn on earth, the world of Hare, could therefore, be termed an extended period of "marginality"—a truly ontological rite of passage—in relation to this final reaggregation to his rightful domain in Winnegago cosmology. (172)

Likewise, it might be said that Yahweh "remembers what he was created to do" and "performs a series of beneficent deeds" for the Israelites. At first, his attention and physical presence is much needed. However, gradually his interventions are less

necessary, and in the end undesired by the people he has shepherded. As a trickster culture-hero, his job is complete and so his physical withdrawal ensues. Like Wakdjunkaga, Yahweh is reassimilated into the divine pleroma—that is, until he is called to aid further cultural development. Heeding the call, he shapeshifts and becomes Jesus, whose exploits are described in the New Testament.

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